Mapping the sustainability branding field: emerging trends and future directions

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Abstract

Purpose – This study aims to offer the intellectual structure and dynamics of the sustainability branding field, involving the identification of influential authors and journals, current and emerging themes, theories, methods, contexts and future research directions.

Design/methodology/approach – The study conducted a bibliometric approach of 1,509 articles retrieved from Scopus to analyze the evolution of the knowledge of sustainability branding and suggest future research. The analysis used various methods such as performance analysis, keyword analysis, cluster analysis and bibliographic coupling.

Findings – The topics of corporate image, philanthropy and stakeholder pressures were core in the foundation phase. Then rose the topics of sustainable development goals and global supply chains. Green marketing and the new paradigms of circularity, ethical consumerism and hyperconnected societies emerged more recently. Six thematic clusters represent the field's knowledge structure: (1) corporate branding and reputation, (2) sustainable business development, (3) sustainable branding and ethical consumption, (4) corporate social responsibility, (5) brand equity and green marketing and (6) sustainability branding in hospitality and tourism.

Practical implications – This paper provides readers with an overview of sustainability branding core themes, key contributions and challenges, which can be used as a toolkit for brand management studies and practice.

Originality/value – The study's uniqueness lies in bibliometric analysis (combined with network analysis and science mapping techniques) of the sustainability branding field from the identification and evolution of the thematic clusters to propose future research directions.

Keywords Branding, Sustainability, Bibliometric analysis, Consumer behavior, Brand communication, Corporate branding, Brand image, Social responsibility, Consumer–brand relationship, Green marketing

Paper type Literature review

Introduction

Branding literature has evolved significantly over the past two decades. The shift from object (e.g. brands provide cues to influence product choices) to self-centered view (e.g. individuals use brands to express their desired self-identities) laid the groundwork for brand affects and symbolic meaning to occupy a central position. This is exemplified by the concepts of brand attachment (Thomson *et al.*, 2005), trust (Chen, 2010), love (Batra *et al.*, 2012), authenticity (Morhart *et al.*, 2013; Nunes *et al.*, 2021) and coolness (Warren *et al.*, 2019). Brands achieved a wider social impact, amplified by hyperconnectivity and social media, creating communities and operating as relationship builders (Fetscherin *et al.*, 2019; Fetscherin and Heinrich, 2015; Veloutsou and Liao, 2022; Veloutsou and Ruiz Mafe, 2019).

Sustainability and well-being are at the heart of this evolution. Brands seek to take a stance on important societal issues and expand their role (Golob *et al.*, 2020; Swaminathan *et al.*, 2020). Unsurprisingly, the body of literature addressing these themes expanded rapidly in the marketing and branding context, as demonstrated by the prevalence of studies on proenvironmental and ethical consumer behaviors (e.g. Copeland and Bhaduri, 2020; Davies and Gutsche, 2016; Hosta and Zabkar, 2021), and the call for achieving a more holistic view of stakeholder value and societal concerns (Marketing Science Institute, 2022). Likewise, practitioners realize the importance of sustainable management for leveraging brand equity and achieving new competitive advantages (Kumar and Christodoulopoulou, 2014).

Given the impacts of sustainability on business, some studies summarized the current knowledge base on specific subthemes related to brand equity and corporate social responsibility (CSR) (Ishaq and Di Maria, 2020; Prasad and Kumar, 2022), but the

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overlap between sustainability and branding workstreams is not addressed. They are anchored on domain-based perspectives, not incorporating a holistic perspective (Veloutsou *et al.*, 2022). Other reviews draw on conceptual, bibliometric or meta-analytical approaches (Bamberg and Möser, 2007; Groening *et al.*, 2018; Nascimento and Loureiro, 2022), examining individual-level behaviors and do not address the impacts of sustainability on branding.

This study aims to address these gaps and provide academics and managers with a state of art and dynamics of sustainability branding research for advancing the field by specifically:

- identifying key contributions and contributors, and assessing the development status;
- describing the evolution of extant literature and prevalent research contexts and focuses;
- illustrating its knowledge structure by categorizing and examining the main thematic clusters;
- determining which topics lie at the forefront of research; and
- based on those proposing future research directions.

The novelty of this work lies in its unique scope and suggestions for future research. The adoption of a predefined protocol ensures a robust and reproducible study of the vast body of literature. The bibliometric analysis uses an advanced set of network analysis and science mapping techniques (Donthu *et al.*, 2021a, 2021b; Mukherjee *et al.*, 2022). The major study areas and approaches are synthesized and assisted by a guiding framework, which categorizes and presents a structured summary of the theories, contexts, characteristics and methods driving the field.

Background on sustainability branding

The organizational theories anchored sustainability in the "Triple Bottom Line" approach and the idea that corporate success is achieved not only by financial results but through social, ethical and ecological performance (Norman and MacDonald, 2004). Corporations began to explore how green supply chain management deals with stakeholder pressures to achieve competitive advantages (Laari *et al.*, 2018; Wolf, 2014). As the focus turns to active engagement, case studies exemplified how sustainable branding stimulates co-creation and circular economy (Brydges, 2021; Morea *et al.*, 2021; Scandelius and Cohen, 2016).

New organizational and social entrepreneurship concepts emerged, reflecting the blurred boundaries between ethical responsibility and business goals (Hota *et al.*, 2020; Moroz and Gamble, 2021). Social responsibility broadens the view of sustainable development, showing that sustainable performance should not be divorced from economic achievement. Sustainable development – defined as *satisfying the needs of the current generation without compromising the ability of future generations to meet theirs* (World Commission, 1987) – impacted management practices and scientific literature with major economic, political, technological and legal implications (Loureiro and Nascimento, 2021).

Sustainability was the focus of social and environmental psychologists concerned with the motivations of social and environmental behaviors, with some of the most important theoretical frameworks anchored on moral aspects (Chowdhury, 2017; Stern, 2000). The marketing literature examined self-accountability and prosocial/environmental cues (Peloza *et al.*, 2013; Sander *et al.*, 2021; White and Peloza, 2009) to investigate consumption tradeoffs and the centrality of green and social/ethical features (Gershoff and Frels, 2015; Luchs and Kumar, 2017). Anticonsumption phenomena (Culiberg *et al.*, 2023) raise questions about whether consumers really care and how they react to social responsibility or green marketing/advertising (Auger *et al.*, 2003; Dangelico and Vocalelli, 2017; Pittman *et al.*, 2022).

The concepts highlighted in the literature evolved independently and do not encompass a holistic view of sustainability (Appendix 1). How sustainability impacts branding is also unclear. Due to the vast and fragmented body of literature, a broader perspective is required for aggregating the multiple dimensions and disciplinary areas.

Methodology

The bibliometric analysis allows researchers to uncover implicit trends in academic production, giving insights for examining core themes and development paths. This study followed a predefined protocol (Donthu *et al.*, 2021a, 2021b; Mukherjee *et al.*, 2022; Veloutsou and Liao, 2022), considering three steps for avoiding the limitations associated with bibliometric and review studies:

- identification of sources and data extraction;
- data cleaning; and
- data analysis.

Identification of sources

The largest collection of scientific research and the most complete metadata and citation information (Donthu *et al.*, 2022; Veloutsou and Liao, 2022) justify the use of the Scopus database. The search query definition was based on the most salient keywords and search terms used in a pool of 27 review studies and meta-analyses related to marketing and sustainability. It was specifically comprised of the overlap between "brand"/"branding" (e.g. Ishaq and Di Maria, 2020) and "sustainab*" (e.g. Nascimento and Loureiro, 2022), "pro-environmental" (e.g. Bamberg and Möser, 2007), "green"/"ecolog*" (e.g. Sharma, 2021), "social responsibility" (e.g. Prasad and Kumar, 2022) or "ethical consum*" (e.g. Groening *et al.*, 2018).

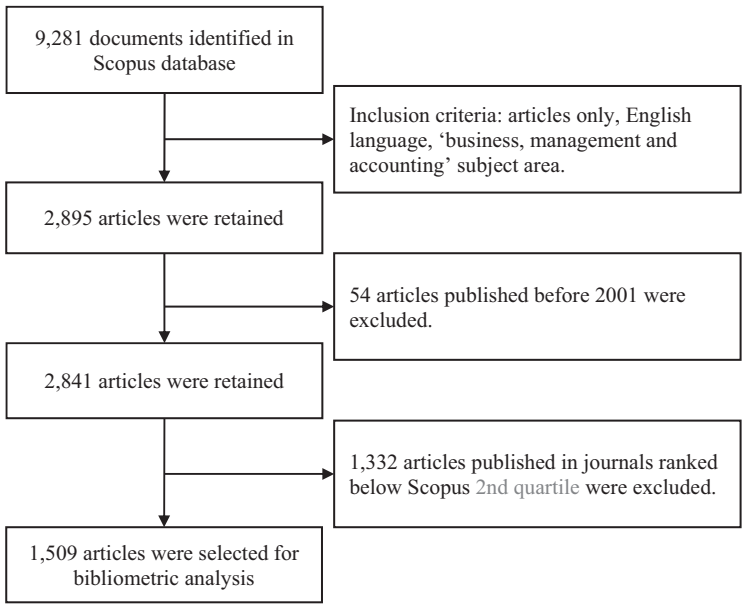
The query was applied to the articles' title/abstract/keywords, resulting in the identification of 9,281 documents, from which 1,509 articles were retained for analysis. The selection comprised the following inclusion criteria: only articles in English and published between January 2001 and May 2023. Articles published before 2001 were excluded because "Triple Bottom Line" and individual-level behavioral theories development started around that period (Norman and MacDonald, 2004; Stern, 2000), which constituted the foundation steps to connect branding to sustainability issues in literature. Only journals from the "business, management and accounting" area were considered and outlets ranked below Scopus Q2 were excluded (Figure 1) to ensure an adequate level of fit and quality.

Data cleaning

Data were cleaned in terms of keywords, authors and journals (Veloutsou *et al.*, 2022; Veloutsou and Liao, 2022; Veloutsou and Ruiz Mafe, 2019). Keywords were merged when the same term appeared with different spellings (e.g. behavior/behaviour), with single/plural forms (e.g. attitude/attitudes), and when different terms

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Figure 1 Literature search and selection procedure



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were detected with the same meaning (e.g. buying/purchasing). Vague terms with imprecise applicability (e.g. variable, fit) and overarching terms (e.g. sustainability, sustainable) were excluded to ensure a clear interpretation. This refinement ended with 5,160 unique terms from the initial list of 5,210 keywords. Next, the database was inspected to ensure that no missing values or data entry mistakes subsisted. The author names and affiliations were checked and, in some cases, were split or merged to ensure homogeneously coded records (e.g. Kang, Ju-Young and Kang, Jee-Won recorded originally as Kang, J. were split because they are different authors, whereas Apaolaza, Vanessa and Apaolaza-Ibáñez were merged because correspond to the same author).

Data analysis

Bibliometric analyses often use performance analysis and science mapping (Cobo *et al.*, 2015; Donthu *et al.*, 2021a, 2021b). While the former uses evaluative techniques for assessing the contributions of research agents, the latter aims to display the scientific production's evolution and intellectual structure (meaning and structural relationships between the different research agents). This is illustrated through spatial representations of how documents, authors or research themes are connected (Donthu *et al.*, 2022; Mukherjee *et al.*, 2022). Both techniques were useful in combining the (a) identification of key contributions and contributors with the (b) analysis of conceptual relationships among them (Cobo *et al.*, 2015), complementing the descriptive nature of performance analyses (VOSviewer, van Eck and Waltman, 2017).

Callon's centrality and density (Cobo *et al.*, 2015; Courtial and Callon, 1991) represent themes' centrality and interconnectedness, indicating relevance (e.g. degree of interaction with other clusters across the network) and maturity (e.g. connectedness within its cluster). The thematic clustering technique used (keyword co-occurrence or co-word analysis) analyzes the conceptual proximity of documents by taking the authors' keywords as a proxy for the actual content's thematic focus, assuming that frequently connected terms are related (Cobo *et al.*, 2015; Donthu *et al.*, 2021a, 2021b). The clusters were positioned in a strategic diagram, a two-dimensional (2×2) illustration of the development status of a given domain, with centrality and density measures represented in the axis.

Keyword occurrence and cluster data (21 years) were divided into nearly identical periods (Donthu *et al.*, 2022; Veloutsou and Liao, 2022) to provide a clear perspective of how the sustainability branding field evolved. Clusters were assigned to the period in which 20% of accumulated network links occurred, signaling the influence of a specific body of literature.

Drawing on the Theories (T), Characteristics (C), Contexts (C) and Methods (M) (TCCM) framework (Bhattacharjee *et al.*, 2022), the content of each period's most cited articles was inspected and categorized systematically. Regarding this framework, in each thematic cluster, the Characteristics are presented first, and then the Theory (T), Context (C) and Methods (M).

Finally, research avenues are presented in terms of areas and approaches. While research areas describe major themes and concepts, approaches address methodological and contextual focus in the literature (Veloutsou and Liao, 2022). The bibliographic coupling – a mapping technique that groups documents citing the same sources (Donthu *et al.*, 2021a, 2021b) – facilitated the recognition of trends, gaps and shortcomings (Mukherjee *et al.*, 2022).

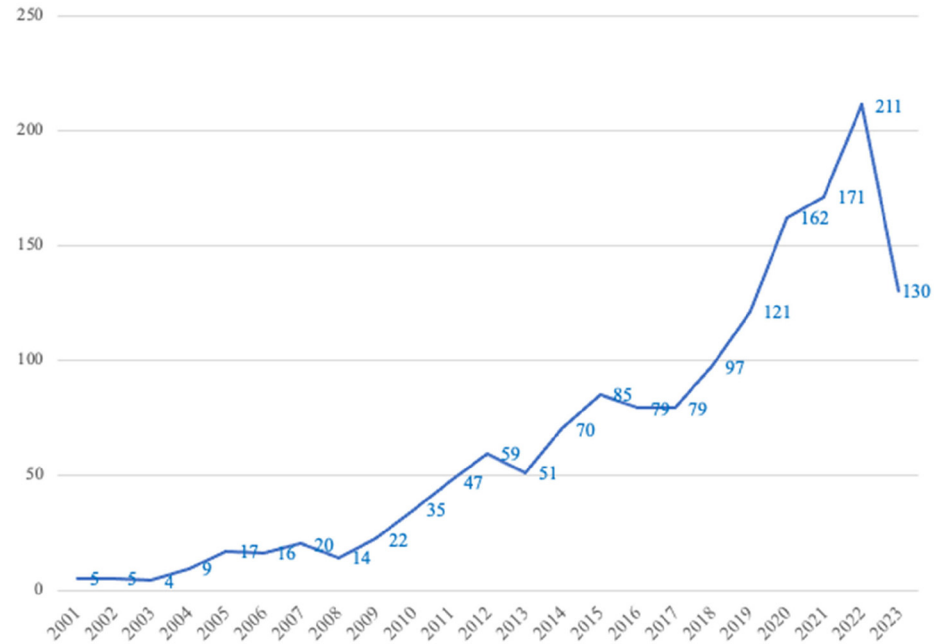
Results

Performance and keyword analysis

The data set (1,509 articles) contains 3,347 authors and 99 different journals and demonstrates the growing interest in sustainability branding (Figure 2). The most productive

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Figure 2 Year-wise trend of scientific production in the sustainability branding field



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journals are the *Journal of Cleaner Production*, *Journal of Business Research*, *Journal of Product and Brand Management* and *Journal of Business Ethics*, all above 50 articles. Based on the first authors' affiliation, scientific production comes from 93 countries, with the USA, the UK and India overcoming 100 articles. Wang, Ahn and Septianto are the most productive authors, while Han, Hartmann and Iglesias are the most cited (Appendix 2 and 3).

From the set of 5,160 keywords, a pool of 388 terms occurred four times or more and were extracted for analysis. Based on their occurrence frequency, the leading topics are CSR, sustainable development, consumer behavior, brand equity, social responsibility, brand image and advertising (accounting for 18% of occurrences). Thematic clusters are groups of keywords that are related to each other based on how often they appear together in the text (van Eck and Waltman, 2017). Six thematic clusters were identified and categorized (Figure 3 and Table 1).

Evolution of research and thematic clusters

The research clusters are characterized according to three phases. The main topics and concepts (characteristics) for each cluster are discussed first, followed by a summary of the prevalent theories, contexts and methods.

First phase (2001–2008)

Cluster 1: corporate branding and reputation. Sustainability was not initially considered a central topic. When the concept of CSR was introduced, it was mostly used for crisis management purposes (Klein and Dawar, 2004). Companies began to take proactive measures in response to stakeholder pressures rather than reacting to them. This is reflected in the initial research about the success factors of philanthropy and cause-related marketing. Findings show that CSR perceptions are more favorable for promoting causes (compared to elaborate advocacy messages) and elicit two main boundary conditions. When consumers are brand-conscious, and the brand's values align with their own, they tend to prioritize the brand over the social cause it represents (Menon and Kahn, 2003; Xiaoli and Kwangjun, 2007).

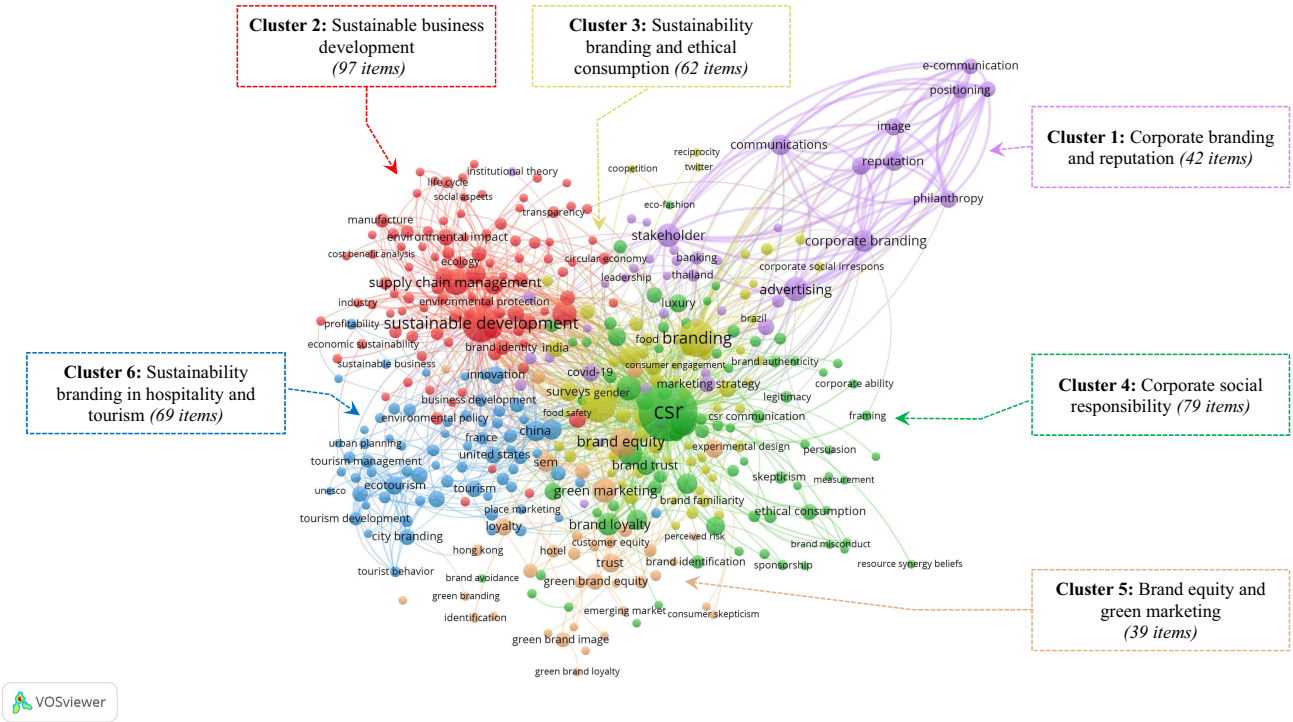
The strategic importance of sustainability branding grew, and new concepts such as eco-design and eco-labeling were introduced (Karlsson and Luttropp, 2006; Sammer and Wüstenhagen, 2006). Concurrently, retailers are often criticized for irresponsible practices, and a measurement scale was developed to assess corporate social irresponsibility (Wagner *et al.*, 2008). The context was examined to explore the usefulness of certification and labeling, as well as how to leverage CSR or sustainability cues to enhance the brand image (Miller and Merrilees, 2013; Sigurdsson *et al.*, 2023; Utgård, 2018). Overall, the social and ethical qualities of products are more valued by consumers than environmental attributes.

Even though this cluster has fallen into a declining status (Figure 4), charity donation (Mazodier *et al.*, 2021) and cause-related marketing (Badenes-Rocha *et al.*, 2022; Bergkvist and Zhou, 2019) are trending topics, raising important questions about whether (and how) companies are embracing them for strategic purposes. For instance, small Chinese firms use donations to mitigate the hazardous effects of environmental misconduct (Wu *et al.*, 2021).

Theory-context-methods in Cluster 1: Organizational, stakeholder and attribution theories were important for laying the groundwork, with an abundance of grounded theory and exploratory approaches. Concerning research contexts, corporate donations and cause-related marketing in developed markets and highly regulated sectors were the main basis of the

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Figure 3 Keyword co-occurrence network and thematic clusters



Note: CSR = Corporate Social Responsibility
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investigation. Regarding methods, data were mostly collected through case studies and in-depth interviews with experts or industry informants (Table 2).

Second phase (2009–2016)

Cluster 2: sustainable business development. As e-commerce, global trade and supply chains expanded, a large body of literature discussed their impacts, addressing topics related to ecology, corporate ethics and stakeholder engagement. The involvement of a larger set of stakeholders, including internal actors and global suppliers, was discussed and important considerations were derived for sustainable operations. Sustainable branding was introduced as a means of unifying diverse corporate agendas and innovative forms of collaboration emerged as a result (Maon *et al.*, 2021; Scandelius and Cohen, 2016). The domains of internal and employer branding gained expression (Carlini and Grace, 2021; de Chernatony and Cottam, 2006), with sustainability influencing a broader set of stakeholders.

Academics discussed new ways to meet customer requirements. First, the social responsibility of suppliers acts as a facilitator (e.g. logistic service providers and interorganizational packaging design) (Laari *et al.*, 2018; White *et al.*, 2015). Second, the entire organization should incorporate sustainable and responsible management principles, even if financial gains are not achieved in the short term (Brydges, 2021). Sustainable development was recognized as a global challenge. The relationship between sustainable supply chains and brand image determined the need to create new measurement indicators.

Theory-context-methods in Cluster 2: Organizational, signaling and attribution theories grounded most studies. Regarding contexts, researchers began to pay more attention to organizations in developing countries besides lean manufacturing and agro-industrial settings (Gandhi *et al.*, 2018; Rueda *et al.*, 2017). Multiple methods are often used with case studies and interviews as the predominant techniques.

Cluster 3: sustainability branding and ethical consumption. Academics explored the connection between sustainability branding and brand value. Corporate reputation, credibility and trust are core drivers (Chen, 2010; Hur *et al.*, 2014; Olsen *et al.*, 2014), yet the excessive usage of green messaging may backfire and trigger greenwashing concerns (Nyilasy *et al.*, 2014; Parguel *et al.*, 2011). This workflow connects to recent work about how familiarity can protect brands from unethical episodes (Nichols *et al.*, 2023).

The willingness to buy/pay more for sustainable products and its determinant factors are core topics. Conflicting views subsist about the balance between proself and altruistic benefits (Nascimento and Loureiro, 2022). Attitudinal-based studies show how purchasing intentions toward socially/environmentally responsible brands depend both on sustainability features and product evaluations (e.g. functional, hedonic and aesthetic) and that sustainability outweighs self-interest only in specific circumstances (Hartmann and Apaolaza-Ibáñez, 2012).

Moral/ethical and self-identity aspects are widely explored. Guilt shapes the influence of self-accountability as a key motive for ethical consumption (Peloza *et al.*, 2013). An emerging area of particular interest is the contradictions between sustainability

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Table 1 Most frequent keywords per cluster

	Keyword	TL	To	APY	TC/NP		Keyword	TL	To	APY	TC/NP
Cluster 1	Advertising	80	47	2012	42.5	**Cluster 4**	CSR	278	386	2017	44.2
	Stakeholder	90	42	2012	54.2		Social responsibility	90	51	2016	33.1
	Corporate branding	43	36	2010	55.5		Brand image	91	47	2017	42.8
	Communications	41	31	2012	47.7		Purchase intention	89	46	2019	28.8
	Reputation	28	27	2008	58.7		Brand loyalty	69	38	2018	38.1
	Identity	31	22	2008	69.4		Brand attitude	51	30	2018	62.5
	COVID-19	46	21	2022	11.1		Green advertising	39	29	2019	26.4
	Philanthropy	21	20	2006	82.1		Brand trust	44	26	2020	20.5
	Image	28	19	2006	72.4		Cause-related marketing	32	24	2016	67.3
	Corporate image	29	18	2014	52.7		Luxury	34	23	2020	30.0
Cluster 2	Sustainable development	221	124	2018	46.4	**Cluster 5**	Brand equity	79	64	2017	49.9
	Supply chain management	103	54	2018	53.2		Green marketing	70	46	2016	72.0
	Fashion industry	95	45	2018	32.9		Trust	49	25	2019	28.9
	Commerce	89	26	2019	21.6		SEM	75	24	2020	40.6
	Decision-making	92	25	2019	47.0		Loyalty	36	21	2018	60.6
	Sales	75	22	2021	33.4		Green brand equity	37	17	2019	63.9
	Brand management	44	20	2015	46.8		Brand awareness	27	14	2016	42.2
	Environmental management	69	19	2016	64.7		Brand experience	35	14	2020	22.4
	Employer branding	25	17	2019	43.2		Green brand image	22	14	2019	90.1
	Environmental impact	66	17	2017	43.8		Perceived quality	45	12	2018	40.4
Cluster 3	Branding	168	122	2014	39.7	**Cluster 6**	China	92	31	2017	55.3
	Consumer behavior	189	108	2016	44.0		Retailing	61	29	2016	36.1
	Social media	55	32	2021	18.7		Ecotourism	61	22	2017	26.0
	Surveys	94	24	2017	57.5		Innovation	51	19	2018	45.8
	Ethics	59	21	2016	36.9		Place branding	29	18	2017	53.1
	India	45	19	2017	31.3		Tourist destination	57	18	2019	23.1
	Environmental	47	18	2017	45.7		United states	68	18	2016	29.1
	Consumer attitude	49	17	2018	38.0		Tourism	47	17	2016	27.7
	Customer satisfaction	43	16	2018	61.5		City branding	28	15	2019	11.6
	Customer loyalty	34	14	2017	54.9		Tourism market	52	15	2018	23.7

Notes: TL = total links (number of network connections); TO = total occurrences; APY = average publication year; TC/NP = number of citations per article; CSR = corporate social responsibility; SEM = structural equation modeling
Source: Created by authors

and conspicuousness (Aagerup and Nilsson, 2016). Consumer sensitivity toward sustainable luxury is relatively stable across cultures, but the underlined motives depend on individual affects and social and symbolic meanings (Kapferer and Michaut-Denizeau, 2014; Septianto *et al.*, 2021).

Theory-context-methods in Cluster 3: Attitudinal-based theories were the norm for investigating sustainable/ethical consumption. Concerning the contexts, sustainable luxury, retail and organic products are core exploration areas linked with recent research about second-hand buying (Jain *et al.*, 2022; Kim *et al.*, 2021) and antibrand or anticonsumption activism (Pöyry and Laaksonen, 2022; Rahimah *et al.*, 2022). Research was conducted mainly through questionnaire-based and experimental techniques.

Third-phase (2017–2023)

Cluster 4: CSR. Earlier contributions examined firms accountable for considerable environmental/social impacts or operating in highly regulated industries. As CSR perspectives evolved, three main questions were addressed: (a) sustainable branding and CSR enablers, (b) outcomes and (c) typologies of CSR. The founder's role was uncovered as a facilitator for creating a sustainable image in two ways: as a cultural architect, energizing employees into environmental issues and as an eco-innovator, maximizing awareness and advocacy (Hillestad *et al.*, 2010).

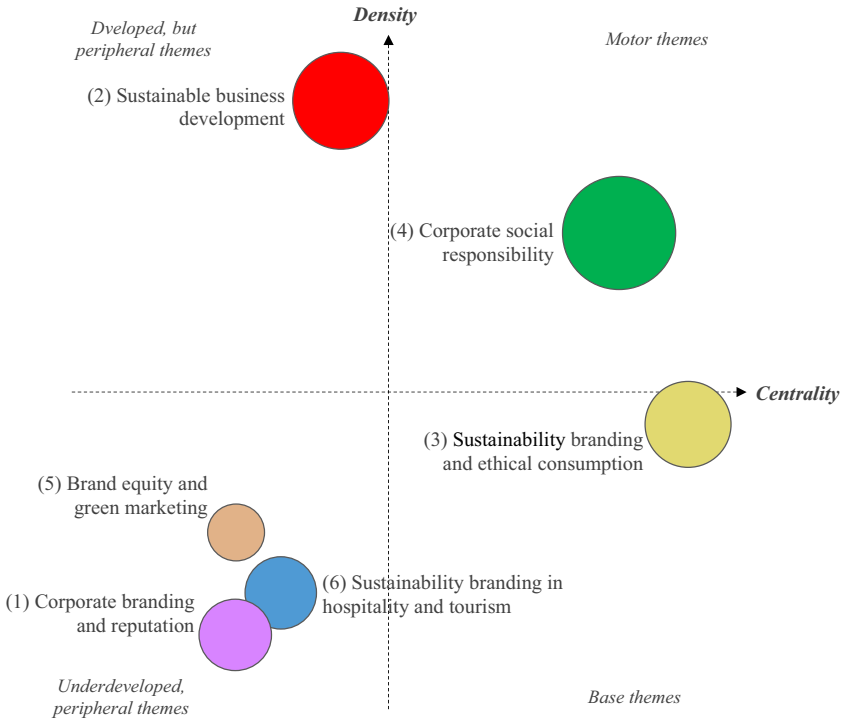
Regarding the outcomes of CSR, brand value is influenced by strategic and normative imperatives. While failing to meet societal and regulatory requirements (e.g. social irresponsibility episodes) may damage value in the short term, strategic and proactive action is the best way to improve brand valuations over a longer period (Agus Harjoto and Salas, 2017; Brunk and Blümelhuber, 2011). Customer engagement is a consequence of CSR-brand fit (Chuah *et al.*, 2020). Brands benefit from adopting a proactive CSR approach to earn credibility.

Finally, new forms of CSR categorization were proposed, including multiple *types* (e.g. sponsorship, philanthropy and cause-related marketing) and *dimensions* (e.g. internal, economical and ethical). However, perceptions are not altered only on the basis of CSR typologies. The combined impacts of brand and benefit types are required to influence customer responses, with the effects regulated by individuals' social status (Lai *et al.*, 2010; Lii and Lee, 2012; Wei and Jung, 2022).

Theory-context-methods in Cluster 4: With regard to theories, construal-level, value and attitude-based frameworks were frequently used. European, Asian and North American were the

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Figure 4 Strategic diagram of sustainability branding thematic clusters



Notes: The size of each sphere represents the volume of research (e.g., number of papers) within each cluster developed and peripheral themes: low centrality and high density. Mature level of interconnectedness but a modest degree of influence over other clusters. Motor themes: developed levels of both centrality and density. Well-established, mature clusters that typically drive research forward. Underdevelo ped peripheral themes: low levels of centrality and density. Suggests either a declining status or clusters at the early stages of development. Base themes: high degree of centrality but a relatively low-density level. Core themes for inspiring other clusters but lacking interconnectedness
Source: Created by authors

core contexts, with many studies examining cosmetic (Morea *et al.*, 2021), oil/energy (Hillestad *et al.*, 2010), fashion (Amatulli *et al.*, 2018) and airline industries (Chuah *et al.*, 2020). CSR topics are explored in social media contexts (Fernández *et al.*, 2022). In methods, experimental designs were prevalent, with the use of panel data and text mining techniques.

Cluster 5: brand equity and green marketing. Several brand equity frameworks were developed. First, a firm-oriented view on brand valuation described internal brand strength drivers, namely, associated with brand identity components, commitment and citizenship behaviors (Burmann *et al.*, 2009). Second, identity-based views emphasize customer-level perceptions (Baalbaki and Guzmán, 2016). Authenticity is important for brands to resonate with customers (Huang and Guo, 2021). The consumer craving for brand heritage and authenticity emerged when analyzing successful approaches of small and global firms (Presas *et al.*, 2011; Wiedmann *et al.*, 2011), but recent findings suggest that dominant brands are perceived as less authentic (Wallach and Popovich, 2023).

With the rise of environmental activism and societal pressures, green marketing become a major theme in management. Activities seeking to minimize the promotion (and/or impacts) of environmentally damaging products/services are adopted by marketers (Dangelico and Vocalelli, 2017). The key questions guiding research are related to the persuasiveness of green marketing claims, which were explored in two areas: the implications for (i) green buying intentions/behaviors and (ii) customer–brand relationships.

Similarly to CSR, the outcomes of green marketing are shaped by symbolic brand meanings. Green claims are insufficient (Guerreiro *et al.*, 2023; Rosenbaum and Wong, 2015) unless brand perceptions are strengthened consistently. The premium price of many sustainable/green brands is identified as a barrier. Customers are only willing to pay more when the brand image meets their self-identity. New relational benefits were identified – depending on relationship length and environmental consciousness – such as confidence and self-expression (Papista and Dimitriadis, 2019).

Personal values, self-transcendence and altruism are important antecedents (Follows and Jobber, 2000). Universal values are associated with global lifestyles and connectedness in cultural identities (Salnikova *et al.*, 2022). Findings show that

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Table 2 Evolution of theories, concepts (characteristics), contexts and methods

	First phase (2001–08, Cluster 1)	Second phase (2009–16, Clusters 2–3)	Third phase (2017–23, Clusters 4–6)
Research areas			
Theories	Organizational and institutional theories (32% each), stakeholder (9%) and attribution theories (4%)	Organizational/institutional theories (9% each), attribution theory (3%), attitudinal frameworks (e.g. TPB, VBN, 3%), signaling theory (2%)	Attitudinal frameworks (6%), cultural/personal and consumption values (4%), S-O-R framework (3%), construal level, game and institutional theories (1% each)
Characteristics	Brand authenticity Brand consciousness and literacy Brand-culture synergies Cause-brand congruence Corporate brand dominance Corporate social irresponsibility Eco-design Eco-labeling Social/product responsibility cues Stakeholder pressures	Brand meaning (social and symbolic) Brand perceived value Consumption conspicuousness Corporate ethical credibility and trust Environmental performance/misconduct Green brand image Greenwashing Lean manufacturing Self-accountability Self-identity Social responsibility of suppliers Stakeholder collaboration/engagement WTP and green purchasing behaviors	Benefit type (self and other) Brand co-creation Brand trust Consumer perceived ethicality CSR-brand fit Customer-(sustainable) brand relationships Destination/place (sustainable) branding Eco-branding Eco-certification Eco-tourism Global cultural identities Green brand equity drivers (internal, external) Green marketing orientation Green materialism Personal values (cultural, moral) Self-cause and self-brand integration
Research approaches			
Contexts ***Regions or countries*** ***Sectors or activities***	Mainly mature economies in North America/Europe (e.g. the USA, the UK, Norway, Switzerland and Netherlands), with some studies in China and other Asian markets Corporate philanthropy and donations (29%), cause-related marketing (26%), banking and financial services (16%)	Mainly mature economies (e.g. the USA, Canada, Australia, Northern and Western Europe), with increasing attention to developing countries (e.g. India and Taiwan) Global supply chains and logistics (18%); luxury and fashion industries (12%); agriculture and foods (8%); hospitality and tourism (e.g. cultural and heritage, 8%); and retail (6%), organic goods (3%)	Europe (e.g. the UK, Norway/Sweden), the USA, Canada and Asian contexts (e.g. China, India, South Korea, Japan, Vietnam and Malaysia) Hospitality and tourism (e.g. eco-tourism, sustainable cities/places, 10%), sustainable luxury and fast fashion (9%), services (2%), automotive and transportation industries (2%)
Methods	Emphasis on case studies (18%) and personal interviews (9%)	Qualitative approaches (44%), surveys (28%) and experimental studies (10%)	Emphasis on surveys (35%) and experimental (10%), with some multimethod and conceptual studies

Notes: Percentages represent the applicable number of articles per phase based on the examination of titles, abstracts and keyword occurrence. CSR = corporate social responsibility; S-O-R = stimuli-organism-response; TPB = theory of planned behavior; VBN = value-belief-norm; WTP = willingness to pay
Source: Created by authors

more globally oriented consumers tend to amplify their green materialism tendencies and are more responsive to green messaging.

Theory-context-methods in Cluster 5: Stimuli-organism-response and identity-based theories are dominant. Several contrasting contexts were explored, namely, developed and emerging markets (Strizhakova and Coulter, 2013), multinational and family-owned firms (Presas *et al.*, 2011), as well as service (Rosenbaum and Wong, 2015) and luxury brands (Kong *et al.*, 2021). Concerning methods, surveys and experiments were mainly used in the cluster.

Cluster 6: sustainability branding in hospitality and tourism. The main question connecting this cluster is how to promote successful sustainable branding strategies for destinations. Community-based and ethical tourism experiences are identified as major trends for the future of the industry, associated with the popularity of authenticity and sustainability (Yeoman *et al.*, 2007). The benefits of certifications were addressed, revealing not only marketing opportunities (e.g. recognition and reputation) but also environmental and financial gains (Jarvis *et al.*, 2010). Resource allocation, time and knowledge are three relevant challenges in the implementation of sustainable strategies, and the lack of education is a major barrier.

Cooperative networks contribute to developing a consistent brand identity throughout the value chain (Lemmetyinen and

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Go, 2009). Maintaining the desired brand meaning among multiple stakeholders is the focus of considerable research interest, with policymakers and academics pursuing different approaches and presenting actionable insights for brand co-creation (Giannopoulos *et al.*, 2021; Reynolds *et al.*, 2023; Tanguay *et al.*, 2013). Effective actor-to-actor communication and shared values were highlighted as major building blocks for creating (and maintaining) destination brand value over time. The ecotourism concept extended the cluster's connectedness and introduced new questions, such as understanding the role of psychological engagement and social media word-of-mouth (Chi, 2021; Quoquab *et al.*, 2021).

Theory-context-methods in Cluster 6: As in other clusters in this phase, rational-based frameworks prevail, with some examples of other theories, such as institutional and service-dominant logic (Giannopoulos *et al.*, 2021). Asian destinations were often analyzed, with an emphasis on green hotels, restaurants, city branding (Aitken and Campelo, 2011) and ecotourism (Chi, 2021). The analysis of methods indicated a balance between exploratory and survey-based studies.

Implications for future academic research

Taking a forward-looking view of the domain, future research avenues are outlined by identifying intellectually related workstreams through bibliographic coupling (Donthu *et al.*, 2021a, 2021b). Based on the most influential contributions and pressing research questions, the following areas and approaches (Table 3) are suggested.

Research areas

Strategic approaches for CSR and sustainability. A future challenge lies in extending multistakeholder approaches to explore how sustainable operations – combined with circularity and business innovation – can shape brand perceptions (Maon *et al.*, 2021), connecting Clusters 2 and 3. Academics are encouraged to examine the broader concept of holistic circularity (Brydges, 2021). Similarly to green product innovations, further inquiries are needed to learn how to leverage green process innovations (Olsen *et al.*, 2014).

Internal branding is an underdeveloped topic, as explored in Cluster 2 (Carlini and Grace, 2021; Muisyo *et al.*, 2022). The perspective of stakeholders should also be accounted for, highlighting the importance of cocreation for sustainable place/destination branding. Addressing multiple stakeholders (with distinct brand meanings) creates new tensions. As Cluster 6 suggests, residents are crucial actors operating as providers and receivers (Aitken and Campelo, 2011; Giannopoulos *et al.*, 2021; Wang, 2019). The conditions that regulate their (dis) engagement due to over-tourism is a promising study area (Reynolds *et al.*, 2023).

Creating value in a hyperconnected world through sustainable branding. Green marketing entails unknown aspects of online engagement to be investigated, as revealed in Cluster 4 (Kong *et al.*, 2021; Swaminathan *et al.*, 2020). With the exponential growth of digital platforms, social media became a predominant ecosystem for brands to signal their sustainability concerns. Thus, it will be relevant to understand how green and social claims in online platforms are perceived by consumers

Table 3 Future directions for sustainability branding research

Research areas	Research approaches
Strategic approaches for corporate social responsibility and sustainability	*Contexts*
Sustainability in employer and city/place branding	Comparing developed to developing economies, and urban to rural settings, smart mobility and transportation, green services and energy, circular/shared consumption and peer-to-peer platforms, non-for-profit and cause-related marketing, small and medium enterprises, customer experiences powered by artificial intelligence, online sustainability branding
The role of co-creation in multistakeholder sustainability branding	
Determinant factors and enablers for green process and product innovations	
Creating value in a hyperconnected world through sustainable branding	*Methods*
Green branding and marketing in social media	Mixed-method designs (combined qualitative and quantitative techniques), Web monitoring and content analysis, from correlational to experimental and choice-based conjoint approaches (e.g. from attitudes/intentions to actual behavioral responses)
Signaling sustainability features and eco-labeling in digital platforms	
Effectiveness in social media for non-for-profit and public organizations	
Authenticity and virtual forms of brand–customer interactions	
Sustainable brand activism and electronic word-of-mouth	
New paradigms for customer-(sustainable) brand relationships	
Importance of brand meanings and affects in customer–brand relationships	
Sustainable luxury consumption: enablers and barriers	
Consumption conspicuousness, self-expressiveness and social status	
Anti-consumption and brand avoidance: drivers and outcomes	
Implications of sustainability for business-to-business and service brands	
Ethical consumption and circular economy	
Implications of sustainability branding for peer-to-peer and shared services	
Shared services and local product consumption: enablers and barriers	
Second-hand consumption: enablers and barriers	
Cause-related marketing and co-branding authenticity: drivers and outcomes	

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(Sander *et al.*, 2021). How to communicate social responsibility effectively in an online context (Fernández *et al.*, 2022)? Considering the relevance of new virtualized forms of brand–consumer interaction, further work should illuminate how its perceived authenticity affects outcomes and modifies brand meanings (Nunes *et al.*, 2021; Pittman *et al.*, 2022).

New paradigms for customer-(sustainable) brand relationships. Brand meaning influences customer appraisals (Diallo *et al.*, 2021), but how do social, symbolic and functional meanings relate to self-brand identification? (Quach *et al.*, 2022; Septianto *et al.*, 2021). More research will contribute to understanding how consumers respond to socially appealing or high-status (eco-friendly) brands, as demonstrated by the evolution of literature in Group 3.

Conspicuous status signaling can result in negative responses, such as brand boycotting or avoidance (Table 3). However, delving into its emotional drivers could help clarify how antibrand attitudes trigger behaviors (Pöyry and Laaksonen, 2022; Rahimah *et al.*, 2022). The topic of conspicuous anticonsumption also deserves attention to understand how self-expressiveness and social identities affect customer–brand relationships (Sekhon and Armstrong Soule, 2020).

Ethical consumers and circular economy. Ethical consumption is a crucial topic of discussion with significant questions for the future (see Cluster 3, Table 3). Peer-to-peer platforms, local products and other sharing economy initiatives have gained popularity due to the influence of sustainability values and online communities. However, brands still face significant challenges in leveraging the sharing economy.

Second-hand buying can be highly uncertain despite its many benefits. Future research could explore how storytelling and blockchain technology might alleviate risk perception by offering insights into the history of second-hand products (Jain *et al.*, 2022; Kim *et al.*, 2021). Cause-related marketing is another promising area for conceptual development, integrating advocacy and authenticity themes (Badenes-Rocha *et al.*, 2022; Bergkvist and Zhou, 2019), which expands on cause-brand congruence and other core concepts introduced in Cluster 1.

Research approaches

Although a wide range of studies focuses on electric vehicles, organic products and sustainable tourism, there is still an opportunity to investigate deeper in these categories. For example, to unveil the ambivalences of electric mobility and shared ownership, considering nonenvironmental gains (e.g. convenience, cost and social value), or to compare organic and local product evaluations. Given the focus on large companies, fashion/luxury and cool brands, researchers should also examine small/medium enterprises and uncool categories to understand how to signal sustainability in functional and/or low-involvement choices (e.g. foods, personal care and green energy). Highly exposed (e.g. retail and public) and nonprofit sectors constitute other interesting contexts.

Further research opportunities lie in understanding the transformation of customer experiences, where sustainability concerns meet technological disruption driven by artificial intelligence and the metaverse. More attention can be given to service brands, exploring how responses to sustainability cues differ across online (vs offline) and robot (vs human-to-human) interactions.

Regarding the research methods, academics should try to overcome the existing shortcomings in sustainability branding literature and consider (a) using mixed-method research designs involving qualitative and experimental fieldwork and (b) addressing the limitations of correlational studies. These approaches are advised, for instance, for observing how to make sustainability claims more effective in advertising and packaging stimuli. In addition, based on the prevalence of social media, a combination of these techniques with Web content monitoring and text mining tools is recommended (Table 3), particularly to explore the new phenomena of virtual brand (and antibrand) communities. There are also relatively few studies using conjoint analysis, which would be appropriate for uncovering the weight of ethical/sustainable attributes in consumer choices.

Conclusion and limitations

This study embarked on a bibliometric analysis to explore the sustainability branding field, identifying the main contributors, emerging cluster themes and offering its intellectual structure. As climate change and corporate ethics have become increasingly prominent in media narratives and public discourse, research on sustainability branding has also gained interest. Particularly, sustainability, sustainable development, CSR and green branding topics are instrumental in developing the network's connectedness, whereas green marketing and brand equity are two frequently discussed and highly interconnected concepts driving the latest research. Digital disruption, circular economy and co-creation phenomena – combined with new forms of stakeholder involvement – pose other interesting new avenues for future work. Although this study has made valuable contributions, it is not free from limitations. First, the analysis is based on bibliographic metadata, mainly the number of publications, citations or co-citations and keyword occurrence frequency, which implies that some topics may receive comparatively more attention than others, disregarding their theoretical significance. Second, the search query could be improved, as articles that do not mention the selected terms explicitly in their title, abstract or keywords were not considered. Finally, the data set considers only peer-reviewed articles. Other documents may be identified and examined in future studies.

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Appendix 1

Table A1 Sustainability dimensions and related concepts in business/management literature

Concepts	Definition/scope	Implications for marketing and branding	References
Anticonsumption	Acts are directed against any form of consumption, with the specific aim of protecting the environment	A growing number of consumer groups are intentionally reducing their volumes of consumption, namely, engaging in do-it-yourself activities, buying second-hand products and/or restraining from driving or flying, based on moral foundations. Recently, service providers and retailers (among other brands) have started to adopt co-creation and sharing platforms, to enable customers to reduce their footprint by endorsing shared consumption, which constitutes a new territory for brands to gain relevance	Culiberg *et al.* (2022)
Circular economy	An industrial system that is restorative or regenerative by intention and design. A sustainability framework that aims to maximize resource efficiency and minimize waste	A new economic model reconciling the economy and environmental protection in a social approach. The possibilities and positive impacts of circularity apply to environmental-conscious consumers and allow brands to resonate with societal concerns. Moreover, constitutes a challenge for organizations to develop new competencies, associated with future competitive advantages, as well as with co-creation, sharing economy and peer-to-peer platforms. It dominates the political and academic discussion on how to make industries more sustainable	Brydges (2021); Morea, Fortunati and Martiniello (2021)
Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR)	A concept whereby companies integrate social and environmental concerns in their business operations, and in their interaction with their stakeholders, on a voluntary basis. *[based on a definition by the European Comission in 2001]*	CSR implementation pushes organizations to go beyond their core boundaries and be willing to expand the scope of cooperation and active communication with a diverse set of stakeholders, involved throughout the value chain. The overuse of CSR claims in brands' communication has led to skepticism from their audiences	Scandelius and Cohen (2016)
Environmentally significant behaviors	(1) The extent to which the behavior changes the availability of materials or energy from the environment or alters the structure and dynamics of ecosystems and biosphere (2) Behavior that is undertaken with the intention to change (benefit) the environment. Similar to "environmentalism." Subtypes: public (e.g. environmental activism) and private sphere (e.g. buying eco-friendly products)	The purpose-oriented definition highlights environmental intent as a cause for behavior, and focuses on consumer beliefs, motives and other mental factors, to drive behavioral change	Stern (2000)

(***continued***)

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Table A1

Concepts	Definition/scope	Implications for marketing and branding	References
Ethical consumerism	Decision-making, purchases and other consumption experiences are affected by ethical concerns	Increasing care about the ethical features of products means new trade-offs affecting consumer choices, influenced by moral judgments, which impacts both the adoption of socially and environmentally responsible products. Ethically minded consumers feel a responsibility toward the environment and/or society and seek to express their values through ethical consumption and purchasing (or boycotting) activities	Auger *et al.* (2003)
Green brand	The specific set of perceived benefits and attributes related to the reduced environmental impact of that brand	Consumer preference for green brands implied that such products/services earn a premium price, as brands started to use proenvironmental claims in marketing communications	Papista and Krystallis (2019)
Green marketing	Marketing activities that attempt to reduce the perception of negative environmental impacts of existing products and production systems. Subdimensions: strategic, tactical and internal orientations	The green marketing orientation acknowledges that the firm's, consumer's and society's need to be satisfied in a sustainable and profitable way, compatible with the natural environment. Creates a new focus on maximizing green brand equity, by improving the brand's positioning/identity and appealing to the audience's environmental concerns	Dangelico and Vocalelli (2017)
Green purchasing or buying behaviors	(1) Purchase of environmentally friendly products that are recyclable and conservable, as well as beneficial for and benevolent to the natural environment (2) Purposeful choice of products and services, intending to (or which may result in) reduced negative environmental impacts during the buying, usage, consumption and/or disposal stages (3) Purchasing practices that consider the environmental impacts of production processes, for example, purchasing recycled products or organically grown foods	The purchasing and consuming of products with minimal impacts on the environment, lead to a new paradigm that considers the environmental impacts of production and consumption (and consumers' own accountability). As a result, rapid growth in expected for market segments, such as second-hand and sustainable fashion, organic foods, green hotels and electric vehicles	Hosta and Zabkar (2021), Nascimento and Loureiro (2022)
Proenvironmental behaviors	Behavior that consciously seeks to minimize the negative impact of one's actions on the natural and built world	Evidence that the actions of an individual or group can contribute to the sustainable use of natural resources inspired a new wave of studies, crossing business/marketing, social sciences and environmental disciplines, to try to close the attitude-behavior gap. Important considerations are presented for cognitive, social, moral and emotional facets of consumer–brand relationships	Nascimento and Loureiro (2022), Stern (2000)

(*continued*)

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Table A1

Concepts	Definition/scope	Implications for marketing and branding	References
Socially responsible consumption	Considers the public consequences of private consumption, and/or those who attempt to use their purchasing power to bring about social change (e.g. incorporate social issues into purchase decisions). Includes – but not restricted to – the evaluation of environmental consequences associated with the purchase of a product. Similar to "socially conscious consumption."	Consumers take into consideration the evaluation of the consequences of consumption upon society and the natural environment, as part of their decision criteria. Socially conscious consumers can be distinguished by a variety of personality, socioeconomic and attitudinal factors	Follows and Jobber (2000)
Sustainable consumer behaviors	Consumption behavior is based on awareness of the long-term consequences of an individual behavior for the natural or social environment	Significant financial implications exist for the businesses involved, and an increasing level of consumer activism is observed (e.g. supporting organic products, made from sustainable materials or respecting fair trade principles, as well as boycotting firms accused of greenwashing or misconduct)	Hosta & Zabkar (2021)
Sustainable development	Meeting the needs of the present generation without compromising the ability of future generations to meet theirs	The United Nations' call for a more fairly distributed economic prosperity, and the urgency of balancing the ability of future (vs current) generations, as well as under-developed (vs developed) nations, to satisfy their primary needs, is changing the paradigms of business globally and becoming a central theme for brand management	Wolf (2014), World Commission on environment and development (1987)
Sustainable marketing	The sustainable approach to consumption and production involves enjoying a material standard of living today, which is not at the expense of the standard of living of future generations	Addresses the business management processes and satisfaction of organizational goals, as well as the needs of customers, society and natural ecosystems. A profound shift is observed in business strategies, for creating new competitive advantages resulting from sustainable marketing as an opportunity for relevant differentiation and introducing a broader view of sustainability in management practices	Dangelico and Vocalelli (2017)
Triple bottom line (TBL)	The idea behind the 3BL paradigm is that a corporation's ultimate success or health can and should be measured not just by the traditional financial bottom line, but also by its social/ ethical and environmental performance	An increasingly popular approach at the beginning of the 21st century for business management, consulting and auditing firms and not-for-profit organizations, which accepts that firms are accountable for a variety of obligations toward stakeholders	Norman and Macdonald (2004)

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Appendix 2

Table A2 Top contributors in the sustainability branding field

Journals	NP	CPP	FPY	Authors and affiliation	NP	CPP	FPY	Countries	NP
Journal of Cleaner Production	91	43	2006	Yuan Wang (Wuhan Un., China)	10	37	2020	USA	318
Journal of Business Research	88	60	2005	Jiseon Ahn (Hanyang Un., S. Korea)	9	17	2019	UK	149
Journal of Product and Brand Management	68	23	2006	Felix Septianto (Un. Queensland, Australia)	8	10	2021	India	115
Journal of Business Ethics	57	124	2001	Jiyun Kang (Purdue Un., USA)	7	13	2014	Australia	89
Journal of Brand Management	48	26	2008	Heesup Han (Sejong Un., South Korea)	6	126	2010	China	82
British Food Journal	39	20	2002	Patrick Hartmann (Un. Basque Co., Spain)	6	112	2012	Spain	72
Corporate Social Responsibility and the Environmental Management	35	32	2009	Won-Moo Hur (Yonsei Un., S. Korea)	6	81	2012	Italy	57
Business Strategy and the Environment	33	53	2006	Arpita Khare (Bajaj Inst. Mng. Res., India)	6	69	2014	South Korea	54
Social Responsibility Journal	33	12	2007	Ipkin Wong (Sun Yat-Sen Un., China)	6	55	2014	Taiwan	47
Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services	32	35	2012	Eunju Ko (Yonsei Un., South Korea)	6	48	2015	France	44
Marketing Intelligence and Planning	32	33	2007	Ian Phau (Curtin Un., Australia)	6	29	2007	Germany	43
International Journal of Retail and Distribution Management	29	35	2007	Pantea Foroudi (Middlesex Un., UK)	6	20	2019	Malaysia	38
Journal of Marketing Communications	29	21	2006	Jing Yang (Emmanuel College, USA)	6	12	2019	Sweden	35
European Journal of Marketing	27	34	2004	Gargi Bhaduri (Kent State Un., USA)	6	12	2015	Netherlands	33
Journal of Consumer Marketing	27	25	2002	Bang Nguyen-Viet (Un. Econ. HCMC, Vietnam)	6	3	2022	N. Zealand	31
Journal of Strategic Marketing	27	20	2002	Oriol Iglesias (Un. Ramon Llull, Spain)	5	109	2012	Canada	29
Journal of Fashion Marketing and Management	26	19	2005	Mohamed Achabou (IPAG Busin. School, France)	5	60	2013	Finland	26
Corporate Reputation Review	23	52	2002	Sihem Dekhili (Un. Strasbourg, France)	5	60	2014	Hong Kong	25
Journal of Sustainable Tourism	23	52	2006	Civilai Leckie (Swinburne Un. Tech., Australia)	5	44	2019	Norway	22
Journal of Global Fashion Marketing	22	16	2013	Kyung Kim (Changwon National Un., S. Korea)	5	33	2014	Denmark	21

Notes: Here, NP = number of papers; CPP = citations per paper; FPY = first publication year; Country productivity is based on first authors' affiliation
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Appendix 3

Table A3 The most influential articles in each period of sustainability branding field development

Author(s)	Title	Journal	Year	TC	CPY	Rank
First phase (2001–08)						
Klein J.; Dawar N.	Corporate social responsibility and consumers' attributions and brand evaluations in a product-harm crisis	*International Journal of Research in Marketing*	2004	852	43	1
Du S.; Bhattacharya C.; Sen S.	Reaping relational rewards from corporate social responsibility: The role of competitive positioning	*International Journal of Research in Marketing*	2007	793	47	2
Xiaoli N.; Kwangjun H.	Consumer responses to corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiatives: examining the role of brand-cause fit in cause-related marketing	*Journal of Advertising*	2007	535	31	6
Berens G.; Van Riel C.B.M.; Van Bruggen G.H.	Corporate associations and consumer product responses: The moderating role of corporate brand dominance	*Journal of Marketing*	2005	463	24	9
Simmons C.J.; Becker-Olsen K.L.	Achieving marketing objectives through social sponsorships	*Journal of Marketing*	2006	455	25	10
Escalas J.E.	Imagine yourself in the product: mental simulation, narrative transportation and persuasion	*Journal of Advertising*	2004	433	22	11
Menon S.; Kahn B.E.	Corporate sponsorships of philanthropic activities: when do they impact perception of sponsor brand?	*Journal of Consumer Psychology*	2003	339	16	17
Schnietz K.E.; Epstein M.J.	Exploring the financial value of a reputation for corporate social responsibility during a crisis	*Corporate Reputation Review*	2005	294	15	21
Fombrun C.J.	A world of reputation research, analysis and thinking –building corporate reputation through csr initiatives: evolving standards	*Corporate Reputation Review*	2005	270	14	25
Sammer K.; Wüstenhagen R.	The influence of eco-labelling on consumer behaviour – results of a discrete choice analysis for washing machines	*Business Strategy and the Environment*	2006	266	15	26
Rokka J.; Uusitalo L.	Preference for green packaging in consumer product choices – do consumers care?	*International Journal of Consumer Studies*	2008	265	17	28
Werther Jr. W.B.; Chandler D.	Strategic corporate social responsibility as global brand insurance	*Business Horizons*	2005	232	12	34
Lafferty B.A.	The relevance of fit in a cause-brand alliance when consumers evaluate corporate credibility	*Journal of Business Research*	2007	228	13	35

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Author(s)	Title	Journal	Year	TC	CPY	Rank
Lafferty B.A.; Goldsmith R.E.	Cause-brand alliances: does the cause help the brand or does the brand help the cause?	*Journal of Business Research*	2005	225	12	36
Karlsson R.; Luttropp C.	EcoDesign: what's happening? An overview of the subject area of EcoDesign and of the papers in this special issue	*Journal of Cleaner Production*	2006	214	12	37
Argenti P.A.; Druckenmiller B.	Reputation and the corporate brand	*Corporate Reputation Review*	2004	198	10	38
Özsomer A.; Altaras S.	Global brand purchase likelihood: A critical synthesis and an integrated conceptual framework	*Journal of International Marketing*	2008	191	12	40
Yeoman I.; Brass D.; McMahon-Beattie U.	Current issue in tourism: The authentic tourist	*Tourism Management*	2007	170	10	41
Singh J.; De Los Salmones Sanchez M.D.; Del Bosque I.R.	Understanding corporate social responsibility and product perceptions in consumer markets: A cross-cultural evaluation	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2008	168	11	43
Fan Y.	Ethical branding and corporate reputation	*Corporate Communications*	2005	162	9	44
2nd phase (2009–16)						
Chen Y.-S.	The drivers of green brand equity: Green brand image, green satisfaction and green trust	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2010	670	48	3
Hartmann P.; Apaolaza-Ibáñez V.	Consumer attitude and purchase intention toward green energy brands: The roles of psychological benefits and environmental concern	*Journal of Business Research*	2012	569	47	4
Lee J.-S.; Hsu L.-T.; Han H.; *et al*.	Understanding how consumers view green hotels: How a hotel's green image can influence behavioural intentions	*Journal of Sustainable Tourism*	2010	560	40	5
Lai C.-S.; Chiu C.-J.; Yang C.-F.; *et al*.	The effects of corporate social responsibility on brand performance: the mediating effect of industrial brand equity and corporate reputation	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2010	487	35	8
Parguel B.; Benoît-Moreau F.; Larceneux F.	How sustainability ratings might deter "greenwashing": a closer look at ethical corporate communication	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2011	383	29	12
Lii Y.-S.; Lee M.	Doing right leads to doing well: when the type of CSR and reputation interact to affect consumer evaluations of the firm	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2012	373	31	13
Awaysheh A.; Klassen R.D.	The impact of supply chain structure on the use of supplier socially responsible practices	*International Journal of Operations and Production Management*	2010	367	26	14

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Author(s)	Title	Journal	Year	TC	CPY	Rank
Braun E.; Kavaratzis M.; Zenker S.	My city – my brand: The different roles of residents in place branding	*Journal of Place Management and Development*	2013	351	32	15
Caniato F.; Caridi M.; Crippa L.; *et al*.	Environmental sustainability in fashion supply chains: An exploratory case based research	*International Journal of Production Economics*	2012	345	29	16
He H.; Li Y.	CSR and service brand: the mediating effect of brand identification and moderating effect of service quality	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2011	321	25	18
Wolf J.	The relationship between sustainable supply chain management, stakeholder pressure and corporate sustainability performance	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2014	320	32	19
Stanaland A.J.S.; Lwin M.O.; Murphy P.E.	Consumer perceptions of the antecedents and consequences of corporate social responsibility	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2011	302	23	20
Brough A.R.; Wilkie J.E.B.; Ma J.; *et al*.	The green-feminine stereotype and its effect on sustainable consumption	*Journal of Consumer Research*	2016	288	36	22
Hur W.-M.; Kim H.; Woo J.	How CSR leads to corporate brand equity: mediating mechanisms of corporate brand credibility and reputation	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2014	280	28	24
Nyilasy G.; Gangadharbatla H.; Paladino A.	Perceived greenwashing: the interactive effects of green advertising and corporate environmental performance on consumer reactions	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2014	266	27	27
Olsen M.C.; Slotegraaf R.J.; Chandukala S.R.	Green claims and message frames: how green new products change brand attitude	*Journal of Marketing*	2014	253	25	29
Torelli C.J.; Monga A.B.; Kaikati A.M.	Doing poorly by doing good: corporate social responsibility and brand concepts	*Journal of Consumer Research*	2012	244	20	30
Peloza J.; White K.; Shang J.	Good and guilt-free: the role of self-accountability in influencing preferences for products with ethical attributes	*Journal of Marketing*	2013	242	22	31
Zhan L.; He Y.	Understanding luxury consumption in China: consumer perceptions of best-known brands	*Journal of Business Research*	2012	241	20	32
Hsu K.-T.	The advertising effects of corporate social responsibility on corporate reputation and brand equity: evidence from the life insurance industry in Taiwan	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2012	240	20	33

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Author(s)	Title	Journal	Year	TC	CPY	Rank
3rd phase (2017–23)						
Sharma V.K.; Chandna P.; Bhardwaj A.	Green supply chain management related performance indicators in agro industry: A review	*Journal of Cleaner Production*	2017	170	24	42
Rueda X.; Garrett R.D.; Lambin E.F.	Corporate investments in supply chain sustainability: Selecting instruments in the agri-food industry	*Journal of Cleaner Production*	2017	124	18	51
Li L.	China's manufacturing locus in 2025: With a comparison of "Made-in-China 2025" and "Industry 4.0"	*Technological Forecasting and Social Change*	2018	522	87	7
Sreen N.; Purbey S.; Sadarangani P.	Impact of culture, behavior and gender on green purchase intention	*Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*	2018	282	47	23
Gandhi N.S.; Thanki S.J.; Thakkar J.J.	Ranking of drivers for integrated lean-green manufacturing for Indian manufacturing SMEs	*Journal of Cleaner Production*	2018	194	32	39
Zameer H.; Wang Y.; Yasmeen H.	Reinforcing green competitive advantage through green production, creativity and green brand image: implications for cleaner production in China	*Journal of Cleaner Production*	2020	159	40	45
Iglesias O.; Markovic S.; Bagherzadeh M.; *et al*.	Co-creation: a key link between corporate social responsibility, customer trust and customer loyalty	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2020	150	38	46
Schmuck D.; Matthes J.; Naderer B.	Misleading consumers with green advertising? an affect–reason–involvement account of greenwashing effects in environmental advertising	*Journal of Advertising*	2018	140	23	47
Markovic S.; Iglesias O.; Singh J.J.; *et at*.	How does the perceived ethicality of corporate services brands influence loyalty and positive word-of-mouth? Analyzing the roles of empathy, affective commitment and perceived quality	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2018	135	23	48
Panda T.K.; Kumar A.; Jakhar S.; *et al*.	Social and environmental sustainability model on consumers' altruism, green purchase intention, green brand loyalty and evangelism	*Journal of Cleaner Production*	2020	129	32	49
Herbes C.; Beuthner C.; Ramme I.	Consumer attitudes towards biobased packaging – a cross-cultural comparative study	*Journal of Cleaner Production*	2018	126	21	50
de Jong M.; van der Meer M.	How does it fit? exploring the congruence between organizations and their corporate social responsibility activities	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2017	123	18	52

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Battistella C.; De Toni A.F.; De Zan G.; *et al*.	Cultivating business model agility through focused capabilities: a multiple case study	*Journal of Business Research*	2017	123	18	53
Ramesh K.; Saha R.; Goswami S.; *et al*.	Consumer's response to CSR activities: mediating role of brand image and brand attitude	*Corporate Social Responsibility & Environmental Management*	2019	116	23	54
Song M.; Wang S.	Market competition, green technology progress and comparative advantages in China	*Management Decision*	2018	113	19	55
Tejedor G.; Segalàs J.; Rosas-Casals M.	Transdisciplinarity in higher education for sustainability: How discourses are approached in engineering education	*Journal of Cleaner Production*	2018	112	19	56
Han H.; Yu J.; Kim W.	Environmental corporate social responsibility and the strategy to boost the airline's image and customer loyalty intentions	*Journal of Travel and Tourism Marketing*	2019	111	22	57
Namkung Y.; Jang S.	Are consumers willing to pay more for green practices at restaurants?	*Journal of Hospitality and Tourism Research*	2017	109	16	58
Szabo S.; Webster J.	Perceived greenwashing: the effects of green marketing on environmental and product perceptions	*Journal of Business Ethics*	2021	105	35	59
Ferrell O.C.; Harrison D.E.; Ferrell L.; *et al*.	Business ethics, corporate social responsibility and brand attitudes: an exploratory study	*Journal of Business Research*	2019	103	21	60

Notes: Here, TC = total citations; CPY = citations per year; "Rank" refers to the overall rank
Source: Created by authors

About the authors

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